

Running the platform

What happens on its own, what needs you, and what it costs each month

The short version

Money now moves from end to end without anybody remembering to make it happen. A shopper buys through a creator's link. The brand's shop tells Pluggz. The sale waits out that brand's returns window. Pluggz invoices the brand. The brand pays. The creators behind those sales are paid on the 1st and the 15th. What is left is Pluggz's own share, and Stripe pays that into the company bank account.

Every one of those steps is scheduled or automatic. The only things that need a person are the ones that genuinely need a decision.

What happens on its own

Three jobs run on the server every night, kept separate so a problem with one cannot stop the others.

Time	Job	What it does
02:10	Clear sales	Releases any sale whose returns window has passed, so it becomes billable
02:25	Billing	Raises and sends an invoice to any brand that owes enough, and reconciles what Stripe has paid into the company bank
02:40	Creator payouts	Pays the creators, but only on the 1st and the 15th

- **Billing follows one rule.** A brand has at most one invoice outstanding at a time, and the next is raised once that is paid. A brand owing less than ten pounds is left until it builds up, because an invoice for eighty pence costs more to process than it collects.
- **Payouts run on the 1st and the 15th**, the cadence the creator dashboard has always promised. The job runs nightly and decides for itself whether today counts, so the promise and the schedule cannot drift apart.
- **A creator Stripe will not pay is held, not skipped quietly.** The reason is written next to their name, and every run asks Stripe again, because Stripe sometimes finishes verifying somebody days after they applied.
- **Stripe tells the platform the moment a brand pays**, so an invoice settles itself. If that message is ever missed, the nightly job catches it.

What still needs a person

Four things, and all of them are decisions rather than chores.

- **Setting a brand's commission rate** when it is onboarded. Everything after that is worked out from it.
- **Deciding what to do about a failed payout.** The platform retries on the next run and records why it failed. Somebody should look if the same creator fails twice.
- **Recording a payment that arrived outside Stripe.** If a brand pays by bank transfer instead, it is recorded with the bank reference on the Brand invoices screen, which releases the sales exactly as a Stripe payment would.

- **Approving creators and brands**, which is deliberately manual as agreed.

Everything else, including chasing what is owed and paying it out, now happens without being asked.

Where to look

- **Money** shows the whole picture in one place: what has come in from brands and what has not, what has gone out to creators and what is still owed, and what Pluggz has earned against what has actually reached the company bank. Each figure sits beside its unfinished half on purpose, so a brand that has quietly stopped paying is visible rather than hidden behind a healthy looking total.
- **Brand invoices** shows what is ready to be billed, every invoice raised, and what has happened to each one.

What it costs each month

Three of these are ours to run and are covered by the maintenance fee. Two are charged on what is actually used and are passed through at cost.

Item	How it is charged	On the invoice
Server and hosting	A Contabo cloud server in Portsmouth, paid annually	Covered by the maintenance fee
Email (Brevo)	Free tier, 300 messages a day, comfortable at the current size	Nothing at present
Cloudflare	Proxy, certificate and protection, on the free plan	Nothing at present
Cloudflare Stream	By how much video is stored and how much is watched, so it grows with use	Added to the monthly invoice, itemised at cost
Stripe	Per payment and per payout, taken out of the transaction by Stripe	Does not appear on our invoice

Creator video

As agreed, Cloudflare Stream is added to the monthly maintenance invoice and itemised separately at cost. Nothing is marked up. In the first months it will be small, because it is charged on minutes and there are few videos.

Video uploads do not work until minutes are bought, so the sooner this starts the sooner creators can post.

What is looked after quietly

- **Backups.** The database is dumped every night and fourteen days are kept. A dump is also taken before any change to the database structure, so a release can be undone rather than argued about.
- **Releases.** The site is built on a separate copy of itself and only swapped in once the build has succeeded, so a failed release cannot take the site down. The previous version is kept and can be put back in seconds.
- **Security.** The server accepts no passwords, only keys, and sits behind Cloudflare so its real address is not published. Rate limits, forgery checks and bot filtering are exercised by the test suite before every

release.

- **Bank details.** Pluggz never holds them, for creators or for brands. Both enter them on Stripe's own pages. That is the whole reason for using Stripe rather than paying by transfer: a platform that never sees a bank account cannot leak one.

If something looks wrong

- **A creator says they have not been paid.** Open Payouts. Either their sales have not been settled by the brand yet, which the Money screen will show, or Stripe is not ready to pay them and the reason is written next to their name.
- **A brand says they have not had an invoice.** Open Brand invoices. If they are not listed as ready to bill, their sales are still inside their returns window. If an invoice was raised but not sent, the brand has no contact email recorded.
- **Nothing has moved for several days.** That is the sign to tell us, and we can see immediately whether the nightly jobs ran.